

"There is no joy in competition if it is to be unfair."

PHOTO: N. SINGH



Milkha Singh

Athlete 1935

FAST AND GENTLE

World class athlete, able administrator, a man who ran for the nation and felt deeply for its sporting spirit, India's best known runner remains its most loved

■ By Ranjit Bhatia

Indian athletics has been through numerous ups and downs from the very beginning, right since the '20s. Still, there have been a small number of athletes who have lived up the scene at the national and the international level. If Milkha Singh stands out as an exceptional track and field person, the credit goes to his determination to become world class.

He held the national records in

200 and 400 m for over 38 years and bettered the Olympic mark of 45.6 seconds at the Rome Olympics in 1960. Born in 1935, he enjoyed a long career till the late 1960s when he turned his attention to golf, grooming his golfer son Jeev Milkha Singh.

I first met him in 1958 at the Commonwealth Games at Cardiff in Wales. He won the 440 yards comfortably and from then on it was steady success for him. He reigned supreme in Asia, dominating the 400 m races.

He was disappointed at finishing fourth in the final at the Rome Olympics and struggled to repeat his Rome performance for the next eight years. Later, he turned his attention to administrative work as the director of sports at Chandigarh.

His first major success as a promoter of sports came when he organised the National Open Cross Country races in Punjab which helped build a running movement in the country and brought in promoters.